Baby Whale Surprises Scientists

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The 2027 baby season for North Atlantic right whales has begun. The **calving** season lasts from November through April, and it is a very important time because the species is **critically endangered**. Scientists watch these whales closely because there are so few of them. Yet one whale managed to keep a secret until September.

Experts spotted a known female and her **calf**, which scientists had not seen before, near Anticosti Island, Quebec, Canada, the New England Aquarium said. The 38-year-old female is called Silt. She is also a grandmother and great-grandmother, and the new **calf** is her sixth baby known to scientists.

'Silt managed to fly under the radar of **survey** teams throughout the spring and summer,' the aquarium said. Scientists do not know exactly when or where her **calf** was born, but she was seen in the southeastern United States **calving** grounds in February, so the **calf** may have been born there.

More North Atlantic right whales are always good news. They are one of the most endangered large whales, and they can be hurt by ships and fishing gear. The 2024 estimate of around 384 whales is a 2.1 percent increase from 2023. But 384 whales is still very low, and scientists are only **cautiously** hopeful because injuries from human activities continue.

Word Treasure

calving -- Calving is when a mother whale gives birth to a baby whale.

critically endangered -- Critically endangered means there are very few left and the animal could disappear.

calf -- A calf is a baby whale.

survey -- A survey is when a team looks closely to find and count something.

cautiously -- Cautiously means being careful and hopeful, but not too sure yet.

Background you need

North Atlantic right whales are a kind of large whale that lives in the North Atlantic Ocean.

A calving season is the time of year when mother whales give birth to baby whales, called calves.

Scientists watch these whales closely because there are very few of them left, and each new baby matters for helping the group survive.

Break it down

WHO: Silt, a 38-year-old North Atlantic right whale, and her new calf, watched by scientists.

WHAT: Scientists spotted Silt with a calf they had not seen before, after she stayed hidden from survey teams through the spring and summer.

WHERE: Near Anticosti Island, Quebec, Canada, after Silt had been seen in the southeastern United States calving grounds in February.

WHY: The calving season matters because North Atlantic right whales are critically endangered, so each new baby gives scientists hope for the species.

Why it matters

Learning about Silt's calf helps you see why protecting ocean animals matters, because every new baby whale can help a rare kind of whale survive for the future.

Test what you remember

1. **When does the calving season for North Atlantic right whales last?**
   - (A) From November through April
   - (B) Only in September
   - (C) From May through October
   - (D) All year long
2. **What is the name of the 38-year-old mother whale?**
   - (A) Quebec
   - (B) Silt
   - (C) Canada
   - (D) Anticosti
3. **Where were Silt and her calf spotted?**
   - (A) In the southeastern United States calving grounds
   - (B) Near Anticosti Island, Quebec, Canada
   - (C) Near a fishing boat far out at sea
   - (D) In the middle of the Pacific Ocean
4. **Counting the new calf, how many babies has Silt had that scientists know about?**
   - (A) Her sixth baby
   - (B) Her second baby
   - (C) Her fifth baby
   - (D) Her fourth baby
5. **How old is Silt?**
   - (A) 38 years old
   - (B) Two years old
   - (C) Six years old
   - (D) 384 years old
6. **What was the 2024 estimate of how many North Atlantic right whales there were?**
   - (A) Around 2,000 whales
   - (B) Around 38 whales
   - (C) Around 6 whales
   - (D) Around 384 whales

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: B 4: A 5: A 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Scientists: Scientists are only cautiously hopeful because injuries from human activities continue, even though the number of whales rose a little.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):